

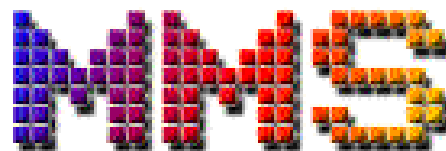
Colours. They rule our lives. We enjoy them. But all along, on a one-and-a-half inch by one inch screen on a mobile handset, all you could see, receive and share were monochrome text-based messages interspersed with the odd emoticon. Then, there's the 160-character limit. While SMS has had its share of the lime-light and was once the killer app in cellular technology, there was something missing—SMS is fun, but it isn't colour-

Partnership Project (3GPP), which is also collaborating with other standards bodies such as the WAP forum to assist in certain areas. The Global System for Mobile Communication (GSM) association is active in collecting operator requirements to address to 3GPP to help advance these standards.

MMS itself will emerge in two phases, the first phase being 2.5G, right now, followed by services on the 3G networks of the future. In practical terms, it means

sages. At some point, additional services are envisaged, such as receiving messages with rich multimedia content from commercial content creators. These services may be commercial transactions, where users would have to pay for them, much like the Web sites that allow users to pay for and download ringtones and logos for their phones.

With the newer mobile devices, people will soon be sharing small video clips or slideshows (complete with audio). In



**You aren't satisfied simply saying it with words? How about adding some colour and pictures?
MMS makes all this possible on your cell phone**

ful. You can send short messages but you still cannot send pictures, videos, audio clips. Creativity is still limited to sending monochrome pixellated emoticons. And it grossly under utilises the bandwidth offered by technologies such as GPRS, which promise desktop-level Internet access speeds on your mobile handset.

Well, not any longer. Multimedia Messaging System (MMS) is the new buzzword in mobile communications. You have heard of it. It promises the ability to send colour pictures, video clips, audio clips and eventually, a whole lot more—a quantum step up from the text-only SMS service and a shift into rich multimedia content on mobile handsets. This shift isn't far in coming; in fact in parts of the world, including India, this is already happening. From North America to Japan, telecommunication companies are integrating MMS services into their network.

What it means

For MMS to be deployed, the network operators have to upgrade their infrastructure and devices supporting MMS must be available.

The principal standards setting organisation for MMS is Third Generation

that at present, under the 2.5G standard (which includes GPRS networks), your MMS messages would look like an animated slideshow or like the Flash files you see on the Internet. With 3G, MMS would be available as streaming video and audio and more bandwidth-demanding downloadable multimedia content.

MMS will allow for several elements within the message. Immediately, we can expect messages with rich text content, photographs (in JPEG, PNG and GIF formats), sound and animation. As with SMS messages, users can create their own mes-

short, MMS is all about dynamic messages. Even if the phone may lack a proper true life colour screen, with shades of greyscale one can still enjoy a dynamic message. Using this technology, you could send picture postcards with phones that feature imaging capabilities, animated greeting cards,



PHOTOGRAPH: Jiten Gandhi,
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